

Chapter 154_1 - Five Years

The familiar broad bridge, with rapids flowing beneath. From time to time, bones would be carried up by the water, spinning on the surface before silently sinking down again, drifting with the river toward the distant darkness.

Ning Fuyi felt neither joy nor sorrow. All the pain in her body had disappeared, or perhaps all her senses no longer existed, leaving only a pair of eyes gazing indifferently at the walking corpses beside her.

She was squeezed among those souls, walking forward step by step.

After walking for an unknown length of time, she finally stepped onto the Bridge of Helplessness¹. Ahead, a ghost was crying. After weeping for a while, it turned and walked toward the cluster of Red Spider Lilies².

Ning Fuyi looked at it with pity, then gazed for a while at the flower cluster that swayed without wind in the darkness, before stepping forward to take its place.

Meng Po's soup³ was bubbling hot before her eyes, with occasional flower petals floating up, along with Meng Po's crushed hair strands.

"Yellow broth thick as tears of former dust, past life's fate ends as it enters the River of Forgetfulness⁴." An elderly voice rang overhead. Ning Fuyi looked up to see an old man with graying beard, holding a ceramic bowl in one hand and a wooden ladle in the other, smiling at her.

His beard was neatly braided, with a deep red Red Spider Lily tucked at the end.

"Drink the soup for reincarnation, or sever all past attachments." The old man handed her the bowl.

Ning Fuyi blinked and took the ceramic bowl with both hands. The soup inside gave off the fragrance of gardenia flowers.

Meng Po's soup originally had no scent. The smell each soul perceived represented their most unforgettable mortal attachment.

Ning Fuyi held the soup bowl for a long time, so long that the souls behind her formed a long queue, with some occasionally making dissatisfied sounds. Only then did she bring the bowl to her lips.

Even though she was reluctant, she knew she had no choice.

She tilted her head back and poured the soup into her mouth. The moment it entered, she heard several alarmed cries from the City of the Dead⁵.

But what did it matter? She no longer had any connection to this world.

Life is the most tenacious thing. Even when flowers and grass wither, after being buried in soil for some time, they can sprout lush green shoots again.

The same is true for people. Even as mortals, they didn't know that such a tragic scene had unfolded in the heavens. They only knew that after twists and turns came clear skies after rain, that ashes from fierce fires became fertile soil, and all things were reborn from the ashes.

The disaster of that day was quickly forgotten. The immortal realm returned to its proper course, and while the opposition between immortals and demons still existed, there were no more major conflicts overall.

More and more sects emerged in the martial world, but every cultivator in the Initial Realm⁶ had to follow protocol and burn a stick of incense toward the southeast.

It was said to commemorate the world's greatest demon lord who had once turned the tide and sacrificed herself for the six realms.

On this day of the summer solstice, the wind from outside the mountains already carried summer heat. In Hanging Beam Courtyard⁷, the sound of reading echoed continuously. Elder Xueyuan was teaching the history of the six realms, sweating profusely from the heat, while the chief elder sat sleeping soundly in the corner. The disciples were enveloped by the sweltering heat and infected by drowsiness, soon nodding off one by one.

At this moment, the door was suddenly knocked, and Liu Wenzhu in green robes carried in a person-high square copper box. Under everyone's gaze, she set down the box. The hollow-carved box blew out streams of cool air from one side, instantly dispelling the summer heat.

"Senior Sister Liu, is this the new contraption from the Flying Flower Sect?" Several disciples in the front row curiously reached out to touch it, but were swatted away by Liu Wenzhu.

"Yes, we only made a few in total and sent them all to Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate⁸. Be careful not to break it." Liu Wenzhu smiled and instructed them to study well, then lowered her head and walked out the door into the blazing sun outside.

"I don't know if it's an illusion, but this year's weather seems much more stifling than previous years." Outside the door, a man with delicate features held a black umbrella, shading himself from the sun.

"I feel the same way." Liu Wenzhu dabbed at her sweat with her sleeve. "Thank you for the Lone Wind Box⁹, and for troubling you to make this trip."

"It's no trouble." Hua Feihua¹⁰ shook her head, raising the umbrella a bit higher as they walked side by side. "How are things with the Liu family? Have those old stubborn ones relented?"

Liu Wenzhu nodded with bright eyes: "Since that battle five years ago, those uncles and nephews in the Liu family no longer dare to say much. Now that my cultivation has surpassed Void Comprehension¹¹ and I have divine protection, even if they still oppose me, they can only repeat the same old words about women being unsuitable for great responsibilities - they can't come up with anything new."

"The position that belongs to me - as long as I don't give it up, no one can take it away. When there are more women who won't yield, those sour words will become fewer too." Liu Wenzhu's voice was gentle.

"That's exactly right." Hua Feihua nodded, the sky's light reflected in her eyes. "If I had your kind of courage back then, I wouldn't have listened to my father and had to disguise myself as a man to claim the title of Young Sect Master."

"If it weren't for that boy Hua Feiwu¹² being so useless - twenty years old and still only in the Initial Realm - this job wouldn't have fallen to me."

"Don't say that." Liu Wenzhu shook her head. "Your cultivation and techniques are not inferior to your peers. I've come this far largely thanks to your inspiration and guidance."

The two stepped over the threshold of Hanging Beam Courtyard. Outside, green shade covered like a canopy, blocking some of the sunlight.

"Alright, let's not be so polite with each other." Hua Feihua smiled slightly, folding her umbrella as her gaze followed the path heavy with green shade all the way to the foot of the mountain.

"Time passes quickly. It's been five years since that day." Her eyes grew distant.

Hearing this, Liu Wenzhu felt melancholy surge in her heart. She stepped over some fallen willow branches and said softly: "Yes, the martial world is peaceful now, but those old friends who used to accompany us can never be seen again."

Seeing her low spirits, Hua Feihua suddenly changed the subject: "Didn't you say a few days ago that you received a letter from Rong Jin?"

"Mm, Senior Brother Rong Jin had his immortal meridians severed back then and was always melancholy on the mountain. Now that he's shed his immortal status and lives in seclusion in the mortal world, he's actually living quite well. A few days ago he wrote saying he met a kind-hearted woman, so there might be good news." Liu Wenzhu visibly brightened thinking of this.

"If Yiyi¹³ could see these things, how wonderful that would be." As she spoke, her eyelashes drooped again.

Not knowing how to comfort her, Hua Feihua patted her shoulder: "Let's go visit the Divine Venerable in a few days. The Divine Venerable hasn't shown herself these past few years. Now that so much time has passed, whether it's physical injuries or emotional wounds, they should be somewhat better."

"Mm." Liu Wenzhu nodded.

Thousands of miles from Cloud Ascension Mountain, in the Demon Realm, the yellow sand rolling across the sky seemed unchanged. The great desert stretched endlessly, with a wisp of lonely smoke rising from the desert toward the fiery red setting sun.

At the entrance to the Demon Realm with its rolling black smoke, a white graceful figure stood on the yellow sand, cold and quiet, hands hanging at her sides within wide sleeves, with a jade-green bracelet on one wrist.

Hair blown by the wind covered her eyebrows and eyes, allowing only a glimpse of her lip color - pearl-red lips with a faint pink tint, pressed tightly together.

The black smoke was dispersed by the wind, and Xi Que¹⁴ appeared with a troubled expression, hurriedly bowing to the woman and saying quietly: "Divine Venerable, it's not that this subordinate won't let you enter, it's just that you know the Demon Lord she..."

"She just recovered her human form not long ago and has lost her memory. When she heard you're from the immortal race, how could she agree?" Xi Que's face was full of exhaustion. "If this subordinate says two more words, she threatens to kill people. This subordinate has no other choice."

The woman in white was indeed Chu Qingqiu. Her body was even thinner than five years ago, standing alone and forlorn in the wind and smoke, showing signs of withering and haggardness.

"I want to see her." Chu Qingqiu seemed not to hear Xi Que's words, only saying lightly.

"Your health is poor, and the Demon Realm is heavy with demonic energy. If you go in, you'll definitely be affected. Why do you torture yourself like this?" Xi Que earnestly pleaded, genuinely pitying this Divine Venerable who had once sat high on a lotus platform.

You must know that when the Demon Lord first died, Chu Qingqiu was like she had died with her. At first, she sat motionless in Penglai like withered wood. Later, when various immortal sects forcibly brought her back to Purple Cloud Peak¹⁵, she wasn't much better. The sects had to send people to watch her daily to prevent her from falling into madness.

Yet it was no different from being mad. During the day she would sit dazed in the flower bed, and at night she would knock everyone down and run out. After the immortal sects spent an entire night frantically searching, she would return in silence.

Immortal Doctor Jiang Li tied her down and gave her a thorough examination, but found no signs of madness. In the end, she could only prescribe some spirit-calming pills and force-feed them to her. Only then did she regain some color, but she still wouldn't speak and would run around day and night.

Later, the immortal sects grew tired, and only Jiang Li and a few others were still willing to accompany her in this torment. After two years of this, one day she finally came back with a black seed in her hand, weeping uncontrollably before everyone.

That was also the first time she had spoken in two years.

According to Jiang Li's assessment, this seed was called Sacred Wood Mandui¹⁶, a rare object that was difficult to produce even once in a thousand years.

No one understood what she meant. They just thought she was lovesick to the point of developing heart demons, so they watched as she carefully marked off a plot of land on the mountaintop and carefully buried the seed in the soil, sitting in front of the mound all day protecting it from wind and rain.

Every evening she fed it with fresh blood, every morning she watered it with flower dew. The sapling grew more vigorous day by day, while her appearance grew more haggard day by day.

Under her blood and flesh nourishment, after another two years, she actually managed to grow a tree. The tree bore fruit, the fruit ripened and fell, transforming into a human form.

That person had phoenix eyes and willow brows, vermillion lips like blood, bewitchingly handsome, with an appearance identical to Ning Fuyi. But her eyes were clear and indifferent, naturally carrying an aura of evil, and on the day of her birth, lightning flashed and thunder roared in the sky. The two treasures, the Emei needle and Xiangsi sword, both hummed in response, as if congratulating their master's revival.

So Ning Fuyi had returned, yet also seemed not to have returned. She no longer remembered anything from before, including Chu Qingqiu.

"I'm not afraid." Chu Qingqiu spoke, interrupting Xi Que's reminiscence.

Xi Que had no choice then, not knowing what else to say to persuade her. At this moment, the black smoke dispersed considerably, and a woman with a graceful figure walked out, waving her hand to pull Xi Que aside.

"Let her come with me." Jiuying¹⁷ said.

"But..." Xi Que was about to speak, but was interrupted by Jiuying.

"If the Demon Lord blames us, just push it all onto me." Jiuying said softly. She pulled open a gap in the Demon Realm and tilted her head toward Chu Qingqiu. "Come on, Divine Venerable."

Chu Qingqiu nodded gratefully at her, then gripped her robes tightly and stepped into the Demon Realm.

The moment she entered the Demon Realm, her heart contracted uncontrollably. Her toes stepped on the rocky, craggy road surface of the Demon Realm - it hurt, but she didn't notice.

The demons coming and going saw her immortal appearance and stopped to stare, with some wanting to approach for a closer look. All were dispersed by Jiuying's gaze and slunk away.

"These days I've used every method possible, but I haven't been able to make her remember the past. Meng Po's soup¹⁸ is truly powerful - one sip and there's never been an antidote." Jiuying lowered her phoenix eyes and pushed open a large door for Chu Qingqiu.

"So when the Divine Venerable sees her shortly, you'll inevitably be hurt, whether in heart or body. Be prepared in advance." Jiuying softly comforted her.

Chu Qingqiu nodded.

Footnotes:

¹ **Bridge of Helplessness (奈何桥)** - In Chinese mythology, the bridge souls must cross to reach reincarnation, where they drink Meng Po's soup to forget their past lives.

² **Red Spider Lilies (彼岸花)** - Flowers that bloom in the underworld, symbolizing death and rebirth. They are said to guide souls to their next life.

³ **Meng Po's soup (孟婆汤)** - A magical soup that erases all memories of past lives, allowing souls to reincarnate without the burden of previous experiences.

⁴ **River of Forgetfulness (忘川)** - The river in the Chinese underworld where souls forget their past lives before reincarnation.

⁵ **City of the Dead (酆都)** - The capital city of the Chinese underworld, where souls are judged and processed for reincarnation.

⁶ **Initial Realm (初境)** - The first level of cultivation in this story's power system.

⁷ **Hanging Beam Courtyard (悬梁苑)** - The name of a courtyard/building in the sect, likely where classes are held.

⁸ **Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate (云际山门)** - The name of Ning Fuyi's sect.

⁹ **Lone Wind Box (孤风盒)** - A magical device that creates cooling airflow, like an ancient air conditioner.

¹⁰ **Hua Feihua (花非花)** - Character name meaning "flower that is not a flower."

¹¹ **Void Comprehension (通虚)** - A high level of cultivation in this story's power system.

¹² **Hua Feiwu (花非雾)** - Character name meaning "flower that is not mist," likely Hua Feihua's brother.

¹³ **Yiyi (衣衣)** - Nickname for Ning Fuyi.

¹⁴ **Xi Que (喜鹊)** - Character name meaning "magpie."

¹⁵ **Purple Cloud Peak (紫霞峰)** - A mountain peak, likely where Chu Qingqiu resided.

¹⁶ **Sacred Wood Mandui (圣木曼兑)** - A mystical tree/seed that can be used to resurrect or recreate a person.

¹⁷ **Jiuying (九婴)** - Character name referring to a nine-headed mythical beast.

¹⁸ **Meng Po's soup (孟婆汤)** - Referenced again, emphasizing its memory-erasing power.